English comprehension and expression: the essentials

> **The big picture**
> Spoken English is hard to follow because it is stress-timed: content words are stressed, function words shrink to schwa, words run together and accents vary. The exam method is always the same: predict, listen globally then in detail, take notes with symbols, then write a faithful, structured report. In speaking, structure everything with signposting and soften opinions and disagreement.

01 Spoken English

Key idea : Real spoken English reduces, links and varies its sounds: to understand it you must expect weak forms, connected speech and different accents.

- Stress-timed language: content words (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs) stressed; function words reduced
- Weak forms use schwa /ə/: to /tə/, for /fə/, and /ən/, can /kən/, of /əv/, was /wəz/
- Strong form returns at the end of a sentence or under emphasis: What are you looking for? /fɔː/
- Connected speech: linking (pick it up), linking R in UK (far away), assimilation (did you /dɪdʒuː/), elision (last week /lɑːs wiːk/)
- gonna, wanna, gotta: recognise them, never write them in professional English
- Accents: UK (RP, Scotland, North, London), Irish, US, Canadian, Australian, and non-native speakers, who are the majority in business
- UK/US: US rhotic (car /kɑːr/), bath /ɑː/ UK vs /æ/ US, US flapped t (water), schedule /ʃ/ UK vs /sk/ US

DON'T CONFUSE

- *can /kən/ (unstressed, reduced) | can't /kɑːnt/ UK, /kænt/ US (always stressed)* : Heard through stress and vowel quality; the final /t/ is often barely audible.
- *Assimilation | Elision* : Assimilation changes a sound (did you → /dɪdʒuː/); elision drops a sound (next day → /neks deɪ/).
- *Accent | Language proficiency* : A strong accent does not mean a poor command of English.

> ***Memory hook :*** *Stress the meaning, squash the grammar: content words are loud, function words whisper in schwa.*

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **Which vowel appears in most weak forms?** → Schwa /ə/, the most frequent vowel in English.
2. **How do you tell 'We can deliver' from 'We can't deliver'?** → can is reduced /kən/ and unstressed; can't is stressed with a full vowel.
3. **/dɪdʒuː/ for 'did you' is an example of what?** → Assimilation (/d/ + /j/ → /dʒ/).
4. **Is the /r/ in 'car' pronounced in standard American English?** → Yes: American English is rhotic; British RP is not.

02 Listening method

Key idea : Listen in stages (predict, global, focused), note only keywords, figures and links, then report faithfully what you understood.

- Before listening: read instructions and title, predict topic and vocabulary
- Listening 1 (global): situation, speakers, type of document, topic, tone
- Listening 2: main ideas and structure; listening 3: details (figures, names, dates, opinions)
- Clues: stressed words, cognates, connectors (but, however, so, because); accept not understanding everything
- Notes: keywords not sentences, symbols, abbreviations, columns or mind map; figures and proper nouns noted at once
- Report: presentation of the document, main ideas in logical order, key details, attributed points of view, conclusion
- Report is objective, in full sentences with connectors, within the required length; invent nothing

FORMULAS

- `Symbols: ↑ increase, ↓ decrease, → consequence, ≠ contrast, = equal, + addition, ∵ or b/c because`
- `Abbreviations: w/ with, w/o without, govt, mkt, co., e.g. for example, i.e. that is`

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Notes | Transcription* : Writing full sentences makes you miss the rest of the document.
- *Report | Personal commentary* : The report stays faithful; give an opinion only if the instructions ask for it.

> ***Memory hook :*** *Predict, Gist, Detail, Rebuild: zoom from the wide shot to the close-up.*

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **What do you do before the first listening?** → Read the instructions and title, predict the topic and likely vocabulary.
2. **What do you identify during the first listening?** → The situation (who, to whom, where, why), the document type, the topic and the tone.
3. **What does the first sentence of a report contain?** → Type of document, source, speakers and topic.
4. **Can you fill gaps with your own knowledge in a report?** → No: you only report what the document says.

03 Speaking

Key idea : A presentation is guided by signposting from opening to questions; interaction relies on polite, softened formulas to give opinions, disagree and check understanding.

- Introduction: greet, introduce yourself, topic, objective, outline (First… Then… Finally…)
- Body: one idea per part, explicit transitions (Let's move on to… / This brings me to…)
- Visuals: As you can see on this slide… / This chart shows…
- Conclusion: To sum up… I'd recommend that we… / I'd be happy to take any questions.

- Speak from notes, do not read slides; articulate and look at the audience
- Interaction: opinion (In my view…), agreement (That's a good point), clarification (Could you clarify…?), rephrasing (So, if I understand correctly…)
- Phone or video: spell names (Alpha, Bravo…), confirm figures, summarise in writing

DON'T CONFUSE

- *I'm afraid we can't…* / *J'ai peur* : A softening formula = « Malheureusement, nous ne pouvons pas », not fear.
- *Presenting* / *Reading your slides* : Slides support the talk; they do not replace it.

> ***Memory hook :*** *Signposts are road signs: tell them where you are going, where you are, where you have been.*

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **Give three transition expressions.**→ Let's move on to… / Let's now turn to… / This brings me to…
2. **How do you disagree politely?**→ I see what you mean, but… / I'm afraid I don't quite agree. / I'm not sure I agree.
3. **How do you buy time or interrupt politely?**→ That's an interesting question. Let me think about it. / Sorry to interrupt, but…

LEARN BY HEART

1. Content words stressed; function words in weak form with schwa /ə/
2. Weak forms: to /tə/, for /fə/, and /ən/, can /kən/, of /əv/, was /wəz/
3. Connected speech: linking, linking R (UK), assimilation (did you /dɪdʒuː/), elision (last week)
4. UK vs US: rhotic r (car), bath /ɑː/ vs /æ/, flapped t (water), schedule /ʃ/ vs /sk/
5. Listening stages: predict, global (situation, speakers, topic, tone), main ideas, details, rebuild
6. Note symbols: ↑ ↓ → ≠ = + b/c w/ w/o
7. Report: presentation of document, main ideas, details, attributed views, conclusion
8. Presentation: opening, objective and outline, transitions, visuals, conclusion, questions
9. Signposting: The purpose of this presentation is to… / Let's move on to… / To sum up…
10. Polite disagreement: I see what you mean, but… / I'm afraid I don't quite agree.
11. Check understanding: So, if I understand correctly… / Could you clarify…?

TRAPS TO AVOID

- Translating 'I'm afraid we can't' as « j'ai peur »: it means « malheureusement, nous ne pouvons pas »
- Writing gonna, wanna or gotta in a professional document
- Trying to transcribe everything word for word instead of capturing gist and details
- Adding invented content or personal opinion to a report when the instructions do not ask for it
- Confusing assimilation (a sound changes) and elision (a sound disappears)
- Judging a speaker's English level by a strong accent

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